

The Glorious Secret Vajra, King of Tantras

Śrī Guhyavajra Tantra Rāja · Toh 383 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་གསང་བ་རྩོམ་པ་ལྟོས་པའི་པོ་

Toh 383 in the Kangyur is a Buddhist tantra known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Guhyavajra Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal Gsang Ba Rdo Rje Rgyud Kyi Rgyal Po, rendered in English as the Glorious Secret Vajra, King of Tantras. It is a tantric scripture belonging to the class of esoteric teachings, structured as a dialogue between the Blessed One and a goddess identified as the Goddess of the Beautiful Long Eyes, in which she requests instruction on the profound and secret wheel — a teaching said to surpass what is disclosed in other tantras. The text opens with a series of questions about the nature of the secret, the wheel, the vajra, and the lotus, inviting systematic exposition of tantric doctrine centered on binding vows and hidden knowledge. As its title suggests, it belongs among the highest register of tantric literature in the Kangyur, presenting itself as a king among tantras and engaging themes of secrecy, initiation, and esoteric realization.

In the language of India: Śrī Guhyavajra Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious Secret Vajra, King of Tantras.

Homage to the Glorious Vajra Ḍākinī.

In the glorious wheel of binding vows,
the secret wheel is not spoken of.

I have not understood the meaning of the profound,
and so I ask that you teach it to me.

The Blessed One declared:

"Listen, O Goddess of the Beautiful Long Eyes!

The secret wheel is exceedingly profound,
and has not been taught in all the tantras.

For your sake, I shall now explain it."

This is the first chapter, the introductory chapter, from the Secret Vajra King of Tantras.

The goddess asked: "Blessed One,
what is this that is called the secret?

What is the wheel thereof?

What is the vajra thereof?

What is the lotus thereof?"

The Blessed One declared:

"The secret is of four kinds.

The first is the palace of the secret,
and then, for the conferral of the secret empowerment,
the second is the palace of awareness.

The fourth's meaning pertains to awareness.

The third is the wheel of Hayagrīva,
dwelling at his very throat.

The fourth is the secret bliss-sustainer,
which is the sustainer of bliss because it abandons wrongdoing.

These in their meaning are the secret:

they enact the conduct of observance and are supremely bold.

Evam — profound and delighting in attachment,
the vital essence flows and blood flows down.

Teach this to the worthy; keep it secret from others.

Vajra-lotus, so called,
is the support in which these four reside,
just as a house rests upon its pillars.
The meaning of tantra is continuity."

This is the second chapter, the chapter dispelling doubts, from the Secret Vajra King of Tantras.

The goddess asked: "Blessed One,
because the distinctions of each have not been sought,
one falls into the mere conventional of the world.
By the unbearable piercing pain of union,
right here in this very state I shall perish."

The Blessed One declared:

"The palace of the secret has six successive levels;
know the number of its petals to be two hundred.

Know the number of Hayagrīva to be nine.

The secret bliss-sustainer has two successive levels,
with the number being fifty-eight.

The palace of awareness has five petals,
and its family is like a flower.

The bhaga is of three kinds — superior, middling, and lesser —
and the skilled yogin should seek it out.
With a pill made of medicine and oil,
anoint the yogin's finger,
and from the perineum fumigate with powder,
and also from the secret place fumigate with oil.
Then the yogin, whether male or female,
should carefully seek that peak with the finger.
Whether it dwells anywhere from two to eight finger-breadths in length or
depth,
the wise yogin should determine this.
There are differences of bhaga — large and small —
and likewise bhaga that is cold or warm,
and fluids that are plentiful yet whose bliss is slight.
For these, the skilled yogin should know:
if the bhaga is large, the bliss is slight —
when the bhaga is large, make it small;
when small, it is said one should develop it accordingly;
when cold, one should likewise warm it;
when the fluids are copious, reduce them.
A woman possesses whichever bhaga of this kind she has.
Therefore, for women, Blessed One,
the skillful means vajra may be thick or thin,
long or short —
the wisdom is fitted accordingly to the means,
and should be taken up in its proper place."

This is the third chapter, the chapter of secret reflection, from the Secret Vajra
King of Tantras.

The goddess asked: "Blessed One,
at the center of what is called Evam,
when seeking the distinctive quality of bliss,
is there any quality here beyond this?"

The Blessed One declared:
"Seek out a place of great seclusion,
with food of many kinds full of essence,
and many drinks of delicious taste,

and saffron and other sweet fragrances;
spread an exceedingly soft seat.
At the ten places of the yoginī,
apply a single drop of fragrant essence at each.
At the five places of the yogin,
likewise apply five drops as well.
Then consecrate the secret sky through blessing.
From the syllable E, visualize a deep triangle.
Within it, from the syllable PAM,
visualize a lotus with eight petals.
At its center, visualize a wheel.

At the center of the wheel, visualize the unbearable-to-touch one.
Then the vajra of skillful means as well:
from HŪṂ, visualize the five-pointed vajra;
from OM, visualize the vajra at the crown;
from PHAṬ, visualize the vajra at the aperture.

Then, upon the seat of bliss,
perform the practice in three aspects:
the preparatory limb of method, and the actual union.
At the twenty-nine places of the wheel,
anoint with the fragrance that gives rise to attachment.
Having eaten the food that gives rise to bliss,
and having seated oneself upon the seat of bliss,
the method partner should moisten the nine places,
and the wisdom partner likewise at the five places.
By means of method, the lotus of wisdom
is moistened, causing the lotus to fully open.
The wisdom partner does likewise.
Signs arise indicating that attachment is arising.

Then, embracing one another,
visualize Heruka and Vajravārāhī.
The wisdom partner extends both legs.
The method partner, endowed with method, moves.
In order to manifest the inner signs externally,
three signs arise in the wisdom mother:
trembling and leaping of the body — the sign of body;

calling out in unbearable cries — the sign of speech;
fainting of awareness — the sign of mind.

To explain the essential nature of this:

this is the secret maṇḍala.

By this, one dispels white hair and wrinkles,
and destroys all the pangs of illness.

This is the extraction of the secret essence.

It is not the outer maṇḍala that is to be visualized;
one abides in the secret maṇḍala itself.

Acts such as fire offering are not to be done.

This secret vajra tantra

will not be heard by all.

The manuscript shall be twelve finger-breadths,
and the manuscript is to be concealed in a secret place.

A fully ripened yoginī
may see it — conceal it from others.

The guru who reveals the secret
is venerable, for he is equal to a buddha.

Furthermore, upon the seat of desire,
having performed all the methods of union as declared,
from fifty up to a thousand,
even if all the yoginīs have no bliss,
by one skilled in the methods of union engaging them,
there is bliss equal to that of the twelfth woman.

A yogin who does not know the methods of union
gives rise to all disorders of wind, bile, and phlegm.

As for the wisdom partner with respect to the method partner:
the wisdom woman who is skilled in the methods of union
should always be relied upon by the method partner.

The yogin skilled in the methods of union
should rely upon the secret of the yoginī.

The goddess asked: "Blessed One,
how is one to rely upon the secret?"

The Blessed One declared:

"In the manner of brother and sister, in the manner of lord and servant,

in the manner of father and child, or in the manner of master and student —
unknown to others, guarding against shame,
one performs the practice in a secluded place.
If one does not rely thus, the samaya is broken,
and in this very life one falls into hell."

The goddess asked: "Blessed One,
what of the yogin without skillful means?
What of the bliss that is without distinction?
What of one who does not rely upon the mudrā?"

The Blessed One declared:
"The secret meaning dwelling in bliss —
for your sake I shall explain it.
A yogin who does not know the methods of union
does not even sit together on one seat,
and does not cultivate thoughts of desire.
If one relies in such a fashion,
it is the ordinary worldly desire,
and after death one is born in the Avīci hell.

The practice of desire is like a mountain of śalmali thorns
with iron spikes sixteen finger-lengths long —
one climbs up and comes back down.
Such a one is called a yogin without skillful means.
Therefore rely upon one skilled in the methods of union.
From the methods of union, bliss arises;
therefore bliss is supremely distinguished.
Bliss without method wastes the body's constitution,
and all disorders of wind, bile, and phlegm arise.

Always rely upon the karma mudrā.
If one does not rely upon the mudrā, the samaya is broken.

At the time of relying upon the mudrā,
male and female yogins signal each other by signs:
when one shows the index finger,
it is asking, 'Are you coming?'
Showing two fingers,
showing the thumb straight,

and likewise showing the ring finger straight — these are called 'the vajra voice' and 'the lotus voice' respectively. If one does not act thus, the samaya is broken."

All the distinctions of signs without remainder are to be found in what is called the Saṃpuṭa.

The goddess asked: "Blessed One, the place of bliss of vajra and lotus — how is it to be held there?"

The Blessed One declared: "Holding there is of two kinds: holding by breath at its height, and holding by awareness. The first is holding by forceful union. Hold through ten kinds of union. One is held by the wrathful goddess through thickness. The support of holding is of four kinds; let one who has the pith instructions understand this. If one does not hold there, by a downfall one falls into saṃsāra. Draw it into the haṃ of meditative absorption. With the tongue, take up the awakening mind, and dissolve it into the wheel of the navel. If this is not done, the samaya is broken."

The goddess asked: "Blessed One, is it by the union of wisdom and method alone, or by the movement of method alone, that the male yogin and female yogin experience bliss without distinction? And what is the very nature of bliss?"

The Blessed One declared: "Movement is set in motion by the woman as well, and the union of method is accomplished by method. From that, bliss is supremely distinguished. For example, it is like silk and coarse wool: by method one experiences only the portion of the coarse wool, while by wisdom one experiences only the hem of the silk. Therefore it is said that the tantra of the yoginī is accomplished by the yoginī. Since it is supreme among tantras, there is no secret other than this one for the consecration of a sacred site, fire offering, empowerment, offering, recitation, tormas, ritual bathing, protection, and so forth. Among fruits, this is supreme: free from conceptual elaboration, it is the five wisdoms."

Then the goddess together with her immeasurable retinue, and all the ḍākinīs, their every doubt concerning desire entirely exhausted, each embraced the Blessed One, made the secret offering, filled themselves with the taste of great bliss, and became invisible.

This is the fourth chapter of the King of Tantras, the Glorious Cakrasaṃvara: the Disclosure of the Suchness of Cause and Effect in the Tantra that is the Secret of Secrets within Secrets, the Vajra Secret.

The King of Tantras called the Vajra Secret is complete.

Translated and established by the paṇḍita Ratnavajra and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

Translator's Notes

- The chapter headings appear within the Tibetan text itself as colophon-style chapter titles, marking the end of each section. The text presents itself as a tantra dialogue between the Blessed One and a goddess named "Goddess of the Beautiful Long Eyes," likely a *ḍākinī* interlocutor standard to this genre.

The term bhaga is retained untranslated as it refers to the female sexual organ in an explicitly tantric physiological context throughout chapter three. This is standard Vajrayāna terminology used in texts dealing with the subtle body and sexual yoga. Translating it with an anatomical English term would lose the technical register; retaining the Sanskrit preserves the text's doctrinal and ritual character.

The syllables E and PAM in the final visualization section are seed syllables used in Cakrasaṃvara-related traditions. The triangle of E represents the bhaga or dharmadhātu, and the syllable PAM gives rise to the lotus, a standard tantric visualization structure.

The phrase "fifty-eight" for the count associated with the secret bliss-sustainer reflects a possible reading of "eight and fifty" in the Tibetan; this is straightforward.

- The phrase rendered as "the unbearable-to-touch one" (不可触者) at the wheel's center likely refers to an intensely hot or sharp deity-form, possibly a wrathful deity at the hub of the visualized wheel; the precise referent is contextually dependent on the larger ritual cycle and is not entirely certain from this passage alone.

The term "śālmali thorns" refers to the śālmālī tree (*Bombax ceiba*), whose branches in Buddhist cosmological hell-descriptions are covered with iron thorns; the image is a standard metaphor for the torments of a particular hell realm.

The hand-signal terminology at the close ("vajra voice," "padma voice": वाज्रस्वरः, पद्मस्वरः) involves two Sanskrit-derived terms of uncertain orthography; the readings here follow the most plausible reconstruction.

- The term "Saṃpuṭa" refers to a specific tantra, the Saṃpuṭatantra, cited here as the authoritative source for the full taxonomy of signs described in the preceding section. The Tibetan reads "Sambuta ru zhes par bya," a phonetic rendering of Sampuṭa.

The silk and coarse-wool simile is an unusual and technically precise comparison: the yogin who relies on method alone experiences only the coarser portion of bliss, while wisdom — embodied in the yoginī — brings the finer, fuller experience, hence the superiority of the yoginī tantra.

The colophon identifies the translator as the monk Śākya Yeshe working with the Indian paṇḍita Ratnavajra, a known early translation pair active in Tibet.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.